Weekly Dinner Plan

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The week at a glance

Five weeknight dinners, none needing more than about 25 minutes of hands-on time on the night itself.

Day	Dinner	Appliance	Hands-on time
Mon	Ground beef taco bowls	Reheat (beef cooked Sunday)	10 min
Tue	Salsa chicken bowls or quesadillas	Reheat (already made)	10 min
Wed	Garlic butter steak bites, green beans	Air fryer	20 min
Thu	Honey garlic chicken, rice, broccoli	Crockpot	5 min AM, 15 min PM
Fri	Peanut noodles with chicken and veggies	Stovetop	20 min

Leftover salsa chicken and honey garlic chicken make easy lunches.

Prep and defrost schedule

The rule of thumb: each night, move the next dinner's meat from the freezer to the fridge. Sunday does the rest.

Day	Morning	Evening
Sat	—	Move 1.5 lb ground beef to the fridge
Sun	—	Brown the ground beef with taco seasoning. Cook 2 cups dry rice (covers Mon and Tue). Mix the honey garlic sauce in a jar.

Day	Morning	Evening
Mon	—	Taco bowls. Move 1.5 lb steak to the fridge.
Tue	—	Reheat salsa chicken. Move 2 lb chicken thighs to the fridge.
Wed	Optional: cube and season the steak	Steak bites. Nothing to move.
Thu	Thighs and sauce in the crockpot, low 5–6 hrs	Cook fresh rice, thicken the sauce, serve. Move 1 lb chicken to the fridge.
Fri	—	Peanut noodles with your premade sauce

Forgot to defrost? Put the sealed ButcherBox pack in a bowl of cold water for 30–60 minutes, changing the water every 30 minutes. Don't put frozen meat straight into the crockpot.

Cooked taco beef and rice keep 3–4 days in the fridge, so Sunday's batch lasts through Tuesday.

Grocery list

Meat comes from ButcherBox, so check the freezer for those first. Tick items off as you shop.

From the freezer (ButcherBox)

- [ ] Ground beef, 1.5 lb
- [ ] Chicken thighs, boneless skinless, 2 lb
- [ ] Sirloin or NY strip, 1.5 lb
- [ ] Chicken breasts or thighs, 1 lb (peanut noodles)

Frozen veggies

- [ ] Broccoli florets, 12 oz
- [ ] Green beans, 12 oz
- [ ] Stir-fry vegetable blend, 16 oz
- [ ] Corn, 1 bag (taco bowls)

Pantry

- [ ] Rice

- [ ] Spaghetti or linguine, 12 oz
- [ ] Taco seasoning, 1 packet
- [ ] Mild salsa, 1 jar (bowls)
- [ ] Black beans, 1 can
- [ ] Low-sodium soy sauce
- [ ] Honey
- [ ] Worcestershire sauce
- [ ] Ketchup
- [ ] Cornstarch
- [ ] Garlic powder
- [ ] Cooking oil

Fridge and produce

- [ ] Shredded cheese
- [ ] Sour cream
- [ ] Butter
- [ ] Flour tortillas (quesadillas)
- [ ] Garlic, 1 head
- [ ] Avocado (optional, for bowls)

Recipes

Salsa chicken and taco beef are your usual versions, so only the three new dinners are here.

Air fryer garlic butter steak bites (Wed)

Serves 4, about 20 minutes.

- 1.5 lb sirloin or NY strip, cut into 1-inch cubes
- 1 tbsp oil
- 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp black pepper

- 1 tbsp butter, melted
- 12 oz frozen green beans

1. Toss the steak with the oil, Worcestershire, garlic powder, salt, and pepper. This can be done in the morning.
2. Air fry the green beans at 400°F for 8 minutes, shaking once. Set aside.
3. Air fry the steak in a single layer at 400°F for 8–10 minutes, shaking halfway. Use 10 minutes for more done.
4. Toss with the melted butter and serve.

Crockpot honey garlic chicken (Thu)

Serves 4, 5 minutes in the morning and 15 at dinner.

- 2 lb boneless skinless chicken thighs, thawed
- ⅓ cup honey
- ⅓ cup low-sodium soy sauce
- 2 tbsp ketchup
- 4 garlic cloves, minced (or 1 tsp garlic powder)
- 1 tbsp cornstarch mixed with 2 tbsp cold water
- 12 oz frozen broccoli
- 1½ cups dry rice

1. Sunday: whisk the honey, soy sauce, ketchup, and garlic in a jar and refrigerate.
2. Thursday morning: put the chicken in the crockpot and pour the sauce over. Cook on low 5–6 hours or high 3 hours.
3. 30 minutes before dinner: cook the rice and microwave the broccoli.
4. Remove the chicken and shred it. Stir the cornstarch mixture into the sauce and cook on high 10–15 minutes until glossy.
5. Return the chicken to the sauce and serve over rice with broccoli.

Peanut noodles with chicken and veggies (Fri)

Serves 4, about 20 minutes.

- 12 oz spaghetti or linguine
- 1 lb chicken, cut into bite-size pieces
- 1 tbsp oil

- 16 oz frozen stir-fry vegetables
- About ¾ cup premade peanut sauce

1. Boil the pasta, adding the frozen veggies for the last 3 minutes. Save ½ cup pasta water, then drain.
2. Meanwhile, cook the chicken in the oil over medium-high heat for 6–8 minutes, or air fry at 400°F for 10–12 minutes.
3. Toss everything with the peanut sauce, adding pasta water to loosen it.

Cut the noodles short for the toddler.

Ideas for future weeks

All five work with your appliances and can be kept mild.

Dinner	Best appliance	Make it family-friendly
Pesto pasta salad	Stovetop, make the night before	Skip feta and lemon. Add mozzarella pearls, cherry tomatoes, and leftover chicken.
Chili	Crockpot or Instant Pot	Ground beef, beans, and mild chili powder. Freeze half for a later week.
Spaghetti bolognese	Crockpot	Grate carrots and zucchini into the sauce. Toddler-friendly pasta night.
Vegetarian curry	Instant Pot	Chickpeas, sweet potato, and coconut milk with mild curry powder. Use frozen veggies.
Chicken tikka masala	Crockpot or Instant Pot	Chicken thighs in a jarred mild sauce plus a splash of cream. Serve with rice or naan.